Tell Tale

By Jeffrey Hatcher

A man, Emil, stands downstage in the light. Middle-aged. A conservative charcoal suit and dark tie. His jacket is buttoned. Behind him are three floral arrangements with flowers in deep reds and purples. Emil stares out front, slightly off to the side.

EMIL: *(Lightly - a hushed chant.)* . . . . I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love yo - *(He abruptly snaps his face forward.)* She-almost-saw-me! *(A moment to steal a glance back at "her." Beat. He breathes a sigh of relief)* Wheww! That was a close one. Real heart-stopper. The beat coming out of my shirt like a bomb about to explode. *Bum?* bum! Bum?bum! Bum?bum! *(He looks off to the side again.)*

I started with just one. "I love you." Very quiet, very small. But audible. ***"I love you.*** " Said to the back of her head as she moved through the room. Holding hands. Smiling. If she turns around in the middle of "I love you," I thought, she'll catch me. She'll catch me, and I'll be happy to be caught. But one "I love you" wasn't really enough. One "I love you" was too ... subtle. So I advanced to two. I went to three. "I love you. I love you. I love you." Nothing. Now I'm up to ***nine***. And this is the first time she's almost seen me say it. What would I have done if she had? *(He stares off at her.)* Next time I'll have to go up to ten.

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INTRODUCTION

Stalkers come from every walk of life and every socio-economic background. Virtually anyone can be a stalker. Take Emil for instance – married, soft-spoken and a bit of an introvert. He works as a funeral director, so his interactions with people tend to be a little, shall we say, scripted. But lately, he's become obsessed with a local real-estate agent; and his infatuation is becoming something of a problem. A scary, creepy, dangerous type of problem. . . Tell Tale by Jeffrey Hatcher

EMIL: Nettie James died yesterday. She was 103. Been on the verge of death for twenty-eight years. Very rich. Terrible woman. I got Tessie in. Not that the James family is going to sell the house on Norton Place let alone use Tessie's real estate company, but it's good for Tessie to be seen, and I got her on the list. She's in the visitation room.

I'm up to 12. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. I love you. There's nothing more obvious in life than one person looking longingly at another - unless it's a person desperately trying not to look at all. (beat)

I hate her name. Tessie. Not Teresa, not Tess - Tessie. I love you. I love you.

We go into the service. My mind withdraws to other places. It's a depressed real estate market. Tessie, she's talented. The way she can describe a house .... I've almost bought four myself. She's on commission, and it's getting tight. A slow season. She tells me about wanting to travel, to get away. Mexico. The Berkshires. Spain. I tell her how difficult it is for me to get away: "No slow season." She laughs. Her laugh. Her smile.

She has not had an easy life. Father was an alcoholic - mother spent twelve years dying in the state hospital - the divorce. And she wears a pacemaker, Tessie - something congenital - to regulate her heart. I love you. I love you. I love you. I have to help her. I will find a way to help her. *(Blackout. Lights come up.)*

I have started to give Tessie advance word of imminent deaths.

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Sometimes I get a warning. Hospital. Police. "A friend in power." Last week Bill Goodpastor tells me his wife Marge has a brain tumor, Bill thinks she may not last the week. Marge is dying, the house is too big, Bill told me, I told Tessie. Unethical? Maybe. It's a slippery slope, but passion is a bracing lubricant.

I love you I love you I love you. I'm up to seventeen now. I'm starting to think she knows I'm saying it, and that's why she doesn't turn. I have considered driving past her house at night. The light in the window, the nose pressed against the pane. But I have restrained myself. That way leads to madness, the padded cell, the perch in the book depository window. I am not like that. Why don't I just tell her? What's the worst that could happen? Mockery. Humiliation. A howl of derision.

Anyway, Marge Goodpastor died yesterday. Bill called from his Jaguar. Tessie came early to the visitation - I wanted to introduce her to Bill before the rush and the cremation. I am making this vow: If my "I love you" gambit does not prove fruitful, I will take drastic action. I will tell her my true feelings before the year is out. Tomorrow is Thanksgiving. I have 35 days. *(Lights fade. Lights come up. Smiles.)*

Tessie said "I hate you" today, and I think there's hope! At The Green Mill. We bumped into each other outside the bank, Christmas shopping. I offered lunch. She said she had to meet Bill Goodpastor to show his house. "BUT," she says ... and I quote her .... "OH - WHAT THE HELL - LET'S - HA VE - LUNCH." *(Big proud grin and giggle.)* What do you think of that! We were talking about these last few "referrals" I've made her. She sold three houses. Good commissions. She's breathing a little easier

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now, and she wanted to take me to lunch. I told her, "You know, I can't keep slipping you these tips forever, we're gonna run out, I'll have to start killing them myself." *(He laughs, mock-sinister.)* HEH-HEH-HEH. She laughed. She said, "You're terrible, I hate you!"

And she slapped me! Just my lower arm, across the table, next to the coffee cup. Her fingers brushed my wrist, near my watch, skin to skin. I almost jumped. Red face. Adrenalin. Dizziness. Vertigo. Just a touch on my wrist.

This has happened to me before. This sort of thing. It goes away. I let it run its course. Lasts a few weeks. This one is in its eleventh month. I will tell her by December 31st. New Year's Eve. But I wish she'd guess it first. I wish she'd tell me. Read my mind, read my lips. Suddenly - out of nowhere - she asks me a question.

TESSIE: Do you know when you're in love?

EMIL: What?

TESSIE: I said, Do you know when you're in love?

EMIL: Oh yes.

TESSIE: How?

EMIL: *(To Tessie in an obviously emotional voice.)* You always know. Knowing isn't the point. The point is action. The point is speaking. That kind of action, that kind of courage ... Why do you ask? *(To audience)* She doesn't smile. She looks at me. Three seconds, eye to eye. One. I love you. Two. I love you. Three. I love you. I'm shouting the words in my mind, but my lips are sealed, surely she can hear me, PLEASE, GOD, LET HER HEAR ME! She breaks her stare.

TESSIE: Never mind.

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EMIL: She'll pay the check, I'll leave the tip. Exiting, I place my hand under her elbow. She allows it. She does not comment. Outside, she kisses me goodbye. Cheek. Another detonation to the skin. My heart is racing. She walks away. Today is December 7. A date that will live in infamy. I have 24 more shopping days. *(Blackout. Lights come up. Tense and angry.)*

Ed Carpolotti died, and Tessie didn't come to the funeral. It was a three day affair! I'd left a message on her machine telling her about Ed. Just the usual. But there was no reply. A day passes. I call her again, get her machine, leave another message. No reply. Two days more. I tell Jim Zimbro: "We should go another day, not everyone who would want to see Ed has had the chance."

JIM: *(looking at him as if he's nuts)* You want to extend it?

EMIL: What about Art Wise. And Johnny Criss and Bill Goodpastor . . .

JIM: Bill's in Florida. He went down Friday. He and Tessie.

EMIL: Bump-bum ... bump-bum ... bump-bum ... bump-bum ... I slam down the coffin lid! My heart is pounding! Had she been seeing him long? Was it him she was talking about at The Green Mill? Did I miss something? Was there a code she was using? Had she been saying "I LOVE YOU" TO ME AND I JUST WASN'T LISTENING? DOES SHE HAVE ANY INKLING AT ALL? AM I A FOOL! BUMP-BUM! BUMP-BUM! BUMP-BUM! Will someone not stop this ridiculous heartbeat! Surely, everyone will hear it! Surely everyone in the room can HEAR IT!!! *(He has reached an explosive crescendo. He finally stops, looks out, fearing he's been caught. His voice is a hushed rasp.)* But they do not turn, they do not hear, they do not see. I am not caught.

The hospital called me at eleven twenty-two. An accident on the drive

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from the airport. Icy roads after Christmas, a slippery slope, a Jaguar over the hill. Bill Goodpastor is dead. So is his passenger. *(Pause.)*

They bring her in the next afternoon. I notice her hair. Gray at the roots. Was she letting it grow out? Or did she just not have the chance to color it? I attach the machine, I prepare the instruments - needles, tubes. Her partial plate out, I smooth the crow's feet around her eyes. I do ... what we do . . . to her eyes, her lips. What we do is ... we seal them. Little known facts. Some things don't burn in a crematorium. Diamonds. Some metals. Heavier bones. Some things you can't burn. Like pace-makers. The heat makes them explode. You can damage the inside of the chamber. So it's important to remove them before you ... set fire to the body. *(He holds up a small transistor-sized object.)* I found this in the preparation room. I really should have given it back to ... someone else. *(He holds it up to his ear.)* It keeps on ticking.

(Pause.) The funeral is crowded. Zimbro asks if there is anything he should add to the service. "Say something about Mexico, the Berkshires and Spain." I've spoken too loudly. Heads have turned. The casket is closed. And by three o'clock that afternoon, Tessie is gone. Across the room I see my wife - *(He looks out front.)*

Tonight is New Year's Eve. My wife is upstairs in bed early, and there aren't any customers in the viewing rooms. For the first time in memory ... we are entirely empty. *(He holds the pacemaker and looks off at her)*

Turn around. Turn around. Look at me, sweetie. Please look at me this time. I'll say it again. I'll say it a thousand times until you turn around and catch me. I love you - one I love you - two ... *(Lights fade to black.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

2003 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2008 National Qualifier
2011 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
IN State Qualifier
MN State Qualifier

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